Unit 3

VITAL SIGNS

3.1 INTRODUCTIONS:

Vital sign are very important indicators of the state of health of a person. They help in diagnosis of disease. This vital signs indicate the basic functioning of the body as follows: **temperature** is the degree of body heat. It shows the ability of the body to produce and lose heat and whether or not the balance is maintained as in normal temperature.

Pulse and BP indicate the action of the heart and condition of the circulatory system. **Respiration** is a vital function of life. By observing respirations we find out how well the respiratory system is working in regard to both lung function and the act of breathing.

Temperature varies with the following factors

- Time of day
- Age
- Exercise
- Temperament
- Place of taking
- Climate

Conversion Scale:

To Convert Fahrenheit into Celsius

$C = (F - 32) \times 5/9$

To Convert Celsius into Fahrenheit

$F = 9/5x\ C + 32$

Sites for taking temperature:

1. Mouth
2. Axilla
3. Groin
4. Rectum

3.2 TEMPERATURE TAKING AND RECORDING:

Equipments for taking oral temperature

1. A tray taking oral thermometer in a jar of disinfectant, such as

   carbolic 1 in 20 (or)

   dettol 1 in 40
2. clean water in a container
3. clean cotton swabs, and small swabs moistened in soap solution
4. kidney tray or paper bag for soiled swabs
5. red and blue pens, temperature book or chart
6. watch with seconds hand

Procedure:

1. Bring the tray to the bedside and explain to the patient, who should be at rest sitting or lying down position.
2. Make sure the patient has not just taken a bath, nor had a hot or cold drink within fifteen minutes.
3. Take a thermometer from the lotion, dip in clean water and wipe with cotton, using a circular movement, from the bulb towards the stem. Avoid touching the part that goes into the mouth.
4. Read the thermometer and be sure it is shaken down to 35˚C (95˚F) or below.

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